Never Been Dissed – Until Now

By Shad Powers

What can I say? Sometimes I'm a little dumb. I consider Cheetoes a major food group. I play air guitar. I think burping is funny. And worst of all, I screwed up my chance with Darcy by listening to a bunch of other jerks who were just as clueless as me.

INTRODUCTION

Growing up is not about when you get a driver's license or when you can legally drink or even when you get married or have your first child. Growing up happens every single time you think for yourself make choices and take ownership of the outcomes of those choices. It's a balancing act between the "what IS" and "what OUGHT to be." Some people never seem to quite make it, others of us are force to grow up way too fast. Never Been Dissed – Until Now takes a quick snap-shot of a growing up experience in the life of one teen-age boy.

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Darcy was kinda like the Jewel CD I loved. I played that thing over and over on the way to school, but the second I pulled into the parking lot, it got stuffed under my seat for, uh, safekeeping and replaced with the Beastie Boys.

Imagine me confessing to my friends that I, captain of the basketball team, was dating Darcy, captain of the debate team. Believe me, I didn't plan on falling for the school brain. But I was blown away by the first words she ever spoke to me.

"Uh, are you lost? This is the li-brar-y. The gym is on the other side of the school, remember?" she said, enunciating the words like she was talking to a toddler. Ouch.

Even though we went to the same school, Darcy and I lived in completely different worlds. She spent her time with the Net nerds, and I roamed the halls like Moses parting the Red Sea of fans who worshipped the guys on my team. I was totally knocked for a loop when she broke the silence.

"Books. I need a book," I stammered, suddenly unable to remember my assignment. She pointed to a row of books on Thomas Edison – just the man I was looking for – and before I could turn to thank her, she was gone.

When I did catch up with her again, she was on her tippy toes reaching for an encyclopedia in the next aisle. "Need a ladder? Or how 'bout some platforms?" I asked, giving her a taste of her own sarcasm.

"How about giving me a hand?" she replied. "Oh, that's right. Books are *square*, not round like a basketball. Think you can hold one?" *Cha-ching!* This girl has guts, I thought. When I started laughing, Darcy totally cracked up and started snort-laughing. The number-two pencils holding up her hair were shaking.

"I can't believe I said that to you. I can't believe you're laughing. This is so surreal," she laughed. "Oh, sorry, that's a big word. Do you need a dictionary?" More laughing, more snorting. We went on like that for a while, ripping on each other until I thought my sides would split.

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For the rest of the day – okay, the rest of the week – every time I thought about her, I felt the same gut-socking, dizzy feeling I get before a big game. Then I found myself taking different routes to get to class just to see if I'd bump into her, and when I did . . . doh! We didn't say a word to each other, but the joke was still going. I'd innocently make gorilla noises, and she'd die laughing. Or she'd take off her glasses and bump into walls, sending her books, pen and protractor flying everywhere. She taped Brain Gum to my locker. I glued a pair of sweaty gym socks to hers. Two weeks into our secret game, Darcy asked me out. Correction: she blackmailed me into a date. I found a ransom note in my locker saying that if I ever wanted to see my lucky jockstrap again, I'd better meet her at a nearby coffee shop. What guy wouldn't love a girl with that sense of humor?

After that first date, we spent nearly every day together talking about everything – cheesy Kung Fu movies (our shared obsession), how I hated being judged as a jock despite my 3.5 GPA, why I hadn't lost my

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virginity – all of the things I could *never* talk about with the guys or would even thing about mentioning to any of the other girls I had dated. Then again, Darcy wasn't like anyone I had ever been with before. She was a lot of firsts for me. She was the first girl who had the guts to ask me out. She was the first girl I didn't judge by her bra size or reputation. She was the first person who made me feel I had more to offer the world than a killer turnaround jumper. She was the first girl I dated who didn't obsess about her hair, her weight or what she was wearing. And she was the first girl I didn't blab about in the locker room when the guys started bragging about their weekend conquests.

It didn't take long for everyone to start wondering why I was flaking on basketball practice or missing the weekly Duke Nukem marathons at Kyle's. I had been making up the lamest excuses to cover for hanging out with Darcy and was feeling pretty skanky about it when the guys confronted me about it. So I told them about her.

"Who?" Steve aske.

4N6 Fanatics

"Not the girl in overalls and hightops?" Eric asked.

"Why are you wasting time on *that*?" Kyle asked.

I sat there as they teased me about slumming with a "geeky chick," assuming that once they exhausted all of their lame jokes about Darcy, they'd move onto their next target. Wrong. After that day, whenever I told them I was doing stuff with Darcy, they unloaded on her again. At first, I didn't let it bother me. Then one morning, Dave asked, "Have you figured out how to get her to wear a bag over her head to the prom yet?" That really pissed me off and eventually the little things turned into big things, like "accidentally" forgetting to tell me about practice or suddenly not having enough room at the lunch table for me.

After a few weeks of getting the cold shoulder from my friends, I started to doubt my own judgment. Darcy wasn't one of the prettiest girls in school. Was I actually planning to take her to my senior prom? She'd probably wear number-two pencils in her hair *and* those hideous hightops. Once I finished picking her apart, I

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was convinced she was totally wrong for me. Darcy didn't like basketball or my friends. She refused to go to any of the team parties. I'd been blowing off practices to be with her, and my game was totally suffering. In my mind, the relationship was doomed.

I tried to be subtle at first by taking different routes to my classes to avoid her. I'd promise to call her but never did. She finally cornered me in the hall one day and demanded an explanation, so I swore I'd meet her after school. Then I blew her off. I was hoping she'd get the hint and go away if I flaked, but she didn't let me off that easily. The next day, in front of the entire school, Darcy let me have it. She yelled at me, called me a coward, a jerk and an idiot, and, worst of all, tossed my friends a box of notes I'd written to her. I stood there speechless as they read each on aloud and laughed like hyenas. The funny thing was that for the first time (*another* first with Darcy) I didn't really care what the guys were saying or who saw me standing there like an idiot, because I knew she was right. When I looked at my friends howling and high-fiving each other,

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I finally realized that I was going to be the first guy in our pathetic circle to grow up.

I wish I could say there was a happy ending to the story, that I begged Darcy to take me back and she did, but it didn't happen. Well, at least not the part about her taking me back. I begged. I pleaded. I stuffed notes in her locker. I followed her around school. I was practically stalking her by the time I realized it was too late. She had already gotten over slumming with a dummy.

Last I heard, Darcy graduated early and got accepted to an out-of-state college. I still feel a little sad when I think about her and what could have been, but I'm also grateful that I learned what I did, when I did. I know a little bit more about who I am – the *whole* me, not just the big man on campus part – and who I can be, regardless of what my friends think or say. So, Darcy . . . . Thanks.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Shad Powers
Book: Chicken Soup for the Teenage Soul III
ISBN: 978-0439237314
Publisher: HCI Teens
Date (Month/Year): April 2000

AWARD HISTORY

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